**Name:** _____

# *New York State Testing Program*

# English Language Arts Test Session 1

# Grade 4

## Spring 2026

# RELEASED QUESTIONS

# Session 1

**TIPS FOR TAKING THE TEST**

Here are some ideas to help you do your best:

- Read the whole passage before you answer the questions. Most questions will only make sense after you read the whole passage.
- You might need to read the passage more than once to answer a question.
- Read each question carefully. Take your time.
- A question may include a quote from a passage. You might need to review both the quote and the whole passage to answer the question.

When you write your answers

- make sure to answer the whole question;
- use examples or details from the text;
- write in complete sentences; and
- use correct spelling, grammar, capitalization, and punctuation.

## *Directions*

**Read this story. Then answer questions 1 through 6.**

*Tyra is captain of the Fernbridge soccer team. They are playing a championship game against the Goldthorpe team. The score is tied, or deadlocked.*

# Excerpt from *Kickoff*

*by Donna King*

1 "Zero–zero," Mr. Wheeler muttered, gathering his team at halftime. "Okay, girls, take it easy; we can do this if we get our tactics right!"

> tactics = plans or strategies

2 Over on the far side of the field, the Goldthorpe coach talked earnestly to his team.

3 As Mr. Wheeler gave instructions, Tyra took deep, steady breaths and exercised her ankle.

4 "Defend deep," Mr. Wheeler insisted. "We need Tyra and Alicia up front, ready for the break, but the rest of you mark tightly and stay back. The vital thing is not to concede a goal!"

> concede = allow or let happen

5 "No pressure there," Molly muttered.

6 "Mr. Wheeler's right," Tyra broke in. "Besides, you have to remember, in this game it's what goes on inside your head that matters."

7 The whole team turned to her, hanging on every word.

8 Captain Tyra spoke on, clenching her fists and leaning forward. "Think winning, not losing. We need to go out there with the right mental attitude —we chase every ball; we never give away possession. And never for a second do we let up on the desire to win!" . . .

9 Too quickly the referee was waving them back onto the field, and the crowd set up their chants once more.

10 "Good luck!" Tyra whispered to Molly and the rest of the defense. "Hey, Alicia, let's go!"

11 Zero–zero in the final. Forty-five minutes and 11 players stood between Fernbridge and glory!

12 Tyra picked out faces in the crowd, including the principal standing next to Mr. Gray, plus talent scouts from three professional teams.

13 *No pressure!* Tyra thought with a wry grin, catching Molly's eye.

14 Once more Goldthorpe started strongly. But this time the Fernbridge defense was solid. They took possession and fed passes out to Alicia and Tyra as planned.

15 "Alicia Webb came within striking distance on three occasions," the reporter noted. "Mega talent—a rising soccer superstar," she wrote beside Tyra's name.

16 The photographers aimed their lenses on the two attackers and clicked.

17 But still there was a deadlock. Minutes ticked by. The girls ran themselves into the ground.

18 Then, out of nowhere, Natalie was onto the ball deep in Fernbridge's half. She dribbled free of a Goldthorpe attacker, looked up, and chose between her two strikers, Alicia and Tyra. She passed to Tyra.

19 *This is it!* Tyra thought. She knew that they could do it this time.

20 "Here!" Alicia called, out on the left wing.

21 Tyra passed, neat and fast. Alicia collected the ball and made a run of 15 yards before a defender threatened her with a lunging tackle. With split-second timing, Alicia fed the ball back to Tyra, jumped the sprawling defender, and ran free.

22 From Tyra back to Alicia with a quick flick. Back again from Alicia to Tyra, and all the time the two girls were working their way up the field, outwitting the defense and approaching the goal. Tyra glanced up. There was one defender and the goalkeeper in her way. The defender came in hard.

23 Pass back to Alicia or take a shot? *Shoot!* Tyra told herself. She swung her right foot and made contact. The ball shot past the defender. The goalie had no chance. The ball hit the back of the net.

24 Alicia's arms were around Tyra's neck, and then Kim and K.D. and Sara jumped on top of them. Tyra went down with the roar of the crowd in her ears. She escaped from underneath a pile of bodies, rolled, jumped, spotted Shirelle's pink jacket, there behind the barrier, and ran toward her family. *Goal!*

25 And that was the final score: one–zero to Fernbridge.

26 "Underdogs Raise the Yorkshire Schools Cup!" the reporter wrote in her notebook, planning her headline for the next day's sports page.

**1** What claim does Mr. Wheeler make in paragraph 1?

**A** The girls can win the game if they have a plan.

**B** The girls will easily win the game.

**C** The girls should work harder during practice.

**D** The girls are too tired to play well.

**2** Which sentence from the story **best** supports a theme about believing in yourself?

**A** "The vital thing is not to concede a goal!" (paragraph 4)

**B** "Besides, you have to remember, in this game it's what goes on inside your head that matters." (paragraph 6)

**C** " 'Mega talent—a rising soccer superstar,' she wrote beside Tyra's name." (paragraph 15)

**D** "Alicia fed the ball back to Tyra, jumped the sprawling defender, and ran free." (paragraph 21)

**3** What does the reader learn about Tyra in paragraphs 6 through 8?

**A** Tyra knows the team needs more practice.

**B** Tyra is a strong leader for her team.

**C** Tyra likes to talk to the team a lot.

**D** Tyra feels angry with her team.

**4** Read this sentence from paragraph 7 of the story.

**The whole team turned to her, hanging on every word.**

The phrase "hanging on every word" shows that the team is

**A** starting to doubt their ability to win the game

**B** ready to end the game so they can relax

**C** listening carefully to what Tyra is saying

**D** not understanding what Tyra plans to do

**5** Where does the reader first learn about a change that leads to the team's win?

**A** paragraph 13

**B** paragraph 17

**C** paragraph 18

**D** paragraph 20

**6** Which detail would be **most** important to include in a summary of the story?

**A** Mr. Wheeler tells the Fernbridge team to not let the other team score a goal.

**B** Fernbridge must make it through the next forty-five minutes to win the game.

**C** Natalie gets the ball away from the other team and passes it to Tyra.

**D** Tyra makes the decision to shoot the ball and scores a goal for her team.

## *Directions*

**Read this story. Then answer questions 13 through 19.**

*A young girl named Little Owl has asked her mother, Spider Woman, to teach her how to weave baskets from natural grasses.*

# Excerpt from "The Dream Basket"

*by Lindsay Koch*

1 Overjoyed, her mother fetched thin strips of river cane. She showed Little Owl how to weave strips over and under each other to make a pattern.

2 It was a much more difficult task than Little Owl had expected, and hours later, with her hands tired and red, she set the unfinished basket aside. She ate a little cornmeal cake with berries and went to bed.

3 That night Little Owl dreamed she was standing on the bank of a great river. As she watched, the river grew narrower and shallower. She stepped into it, and the water came up to her knees. A fish swam around her legs and called out her name in a silver voice, like water splashing on stone. Little Owl found that she could understand the fish perfectly.

4 "You are a good daughter, Little Owl. You must listen to me and help your people," the fish told her. "A time is coming when the water will dry up. Tell your people to fill their water jars now. Tell them to catch my brothers and hunt the animals of the forest now, before they return to the Great Spirit in the hard time to come. Listen to me and remember!" With that, the fish disappeared in a trail of bubbles.

5 The next morning Little Owl woke to hear her mother calling, "Little Owl, go fetch some water."

6 Little Owl rose from her bed, rubbed her eyes, and reached for the jar that always stood by the deer-hide door. The morning sun shone bright and warm on her face as she walked down to the stream. When she bent to fill the jar, she spotted something shiny in the mud of the bank and pried out a piece of clamshell, pearly and white in the daylight. It was shaped like a small fish.

pried out = pulled loose or opened with a tool

7 Suddenly her dream came rushing back to her, and she lost her grip on the handle of the jar. A fish had swum into her dreams the night before, a fish with a message. Little Owl knew that the message had been important, but try as she might, she couldn't remember it. She slipped the shell into her pocket, picked up the water jar, and walked back to the house.

8 Little Owl worked on her basket again, humming as she wove the strips of cane in and out. Spider Woman smiled and said, "It is good work. Your weaving is tight and strong."

9 That evening Little Owl placed the still unfinished basket by her bed. As she lay down, she felt the clamshell in her pocket. "I wish I could remember," she said with a sigh, dropping the shell into the basket. She fell into a deep sleep and into the arms of another amazing dream. She was standing at the edge of a field of waving, green corn. A strong, hot wind came up from the south, stinging her cheeks like fire. The corn leaned toward her, and in the rustling of the stalks, she heard a whispery voice. It was the language of green, growing things, of the earth and the wind and the rain. She found she could understand it perfectly.

10 "Little Owl, you must listen to me and help your people. A time is coming when the rain will stop falling and the earth will dry up. Tell your people to save the corn. Water part of the field so that all is not lost. Take what other plants you need now, before they wither away. Listen well, Little Owl, and remember!" The wind died down, and the corn stood silent again.

11 The next morning Little Owl hurried to the willow marsh to cut twigs for basket-making. When she reached up for one last branch, she spied an abandoned bird's nest in the crook of a limb. It reminded her of a little basket.

abandoned = left behind empty

12 Curious, she pulled it down and peered inside. She expected to find broken bits of eggshell; instead, her eyes fell upon a handful of dark, purple-red kernels of corn. "This nest must be a squirrel's basket," she said with a laugh. But the corn touched a memory inside her, the memory of her dream. Little Owl heard the whispery voice in the cornstalks again, warning her about the end of the rain. The silvery voice of the fish in the river came back to her, too, warning her that the water would dry up. Suddenly she understood what these dreams meant for her people. She had to tell someone!

**13** What do the details in paragraphs 1 and 8 reveal about Spider Woman?

**A** She knows what others need.

**B** She knows about many things.

**C** She is an encouraging person.

**D** She is a very careful person.

**14** It is said that it is important to be prepared in case of a problem. Which sentence **best** shows how this idea is shown in the story?

**A** "Tell them to catch my brothers and hunt the animals of the forest now, before they return to the Great Spirit in the hard time to come." (paragraph 4)

**B** "The next morning Little Owl woke to hear her mother calling, 'Little Owl, go fetch some water.' " (paragraph 5)

**C** "She slipped the shell into her pocket, picked up the water jar, and walked back to the house." (paragraph 7)

**D** "She expected to find broken bits of eggshell; instead, her eyes fell upon a handful of dark, purple-red kernels of corn." (paragraph 12)

**15** How are paragraph 4 and paragraph 10 related?

**A** by telling how the first dream causes Little Owl to have another dream

**B** by using dialogue to make a point about Little Owl's people

**C** by comparing how Little Owl feels after each of her dreams

**D** by telling how Little Owl can solve a problem by warning her people

**16** Which detail from the story **best** supports the fish's claim that Little Owl is a good daughter?

**A** Little Owl eats only a little cake and berries before going to bed.

**B** Little Owl gets out of bed when her mother tells her to go get water.

**C** Little Owl weaves a basket and her mother checks the work.

**D** Little Owl goes to the marsh to gather twigs for basket-making.

**17** What does the reader learn about Little Owl in paragraph 6?

**A** She forgets what she is doing easily.

**B** She notices the things around her.

**C** She enjoys collecting things for herself.

**D** She dislikes doing chores in the morning.

**18** Read this sentence from paragraph 7.

> **Suddenly her dream came rushing back to her, and she lost her grip on the handle of the jar.**

What does the phrase "rushing back to her" mean as used in the sentence?

**A** Little Owl remembers events from her dream.

**B** The dream causes Little Owl to feel upset.

**C** The jar of water is too heavy for Little Owl.

**D** Little Owl must hurry home with the water.

**19** How do Little Owl's actions in the story support a theme of listening to nature?

**A** She follows directions to weave a good basket.

**B** She works hard collecting water for her family.

**C** She gathers things from the marsh to share.

**D** She plans to tell someone about her dreams.

*Directions*
**Read this article. Then answer questions 20 through 25.**

# Excerpt from "Riding the First Balloons"

*by David L. Bristow*

1 In 1783, if you wanted to go somewhere, you could walk, ride a horse, or sail in a ship. Flying was out of the question. No one had ever sailed into the sky, and there was no reason to think that anyone ever would. . . .

**Hot Air Power**

2 Ballooning started with Joseph Montgolfier, who was not the sort of person you'd expect to be an inventor. He didn't like school and ran away from home as a teenager. As a grownup, he failed in business. He was very unlike his younger brother, Étienne, who was responsible and successful. But when Joseph started reading on his own, he discovered that he loved science and experiments. A lot of good science starts with simply paying attention and thinking about what you've seen. Joseph made a common observation and then did something amazing with it.

3 Joseph noticed that hot air rises. Everyone knew that. He also noticed that rising hot air can carry solid objects with it. If you've ever watched bits of ash rising with the smoke from a fire, you've seen it too.

4 He wondered, what if I filled a cloth bag with hot air? Would the rising air lift the bag? Only one way to find out!

5 Sure enough, bags filled with hot air rose up. Soon, Joseph and Étienne were making larger and larger cloth bags, which they called *ballons*, the French word for ball. They held public demonstrations, filling the balloons over a fire pit and letting them go. The balloons went up and then came down as the air inside cooled off. . . .

**Up, Up, and Away**

6 Joseph and Étienne wanted to send people up in a balloon, but they didn't want to go themselves. They may have thought it was dangerous. And the king of France wouldn't allow it until one more experiment was made.

7 So the first to fly in a balloon were not its inventors, but a sheep, a rooster, and a duck. They went up together in a wicker cage. Would there be enough air to breathe so high up? Would the balloon come down too fast?

8 Tens of thousands of people watched the animals ascend. The animals flew high and landed without harm 2 miles (3 km) away, but the king was still reluctant. . . .

ascend = rise

reluctant = unsure

9 Jean-François Pilâtre de Rozier was an energetic man. He ran a science museum and invented an early type of gas mask to protect workers in sewers. When he heard about balloons, he wanted to be part of the experiments. He wanted to be the first person to fly! But who was he to talk to a king? He needed help from a nobleman. So he offered the Marquis d'Arlandes a deal: Convince the king to let me fly, and you can come along too. The plan worked. And so, before an enormous crowd just outside of Paris, the two men climbed aboard a tall and beautifully decorated balloon.

nobleman = important person

10 Unlike the Montgolfiers' early balloons, this one would carry its own fire. It had a doughnut-shaped basket to carry the passengers. In the center was a fire basket where they would throw bundles of straw. By tending the fire, they could control whether they went up or down—though they had no way to steer, so they would go in whatever direction the wind took them. . . .

11 The crowd stood still and silent as the great balloon rose slowly into the air. D'Arlandes leaned out, staring down at the crowd as they stared up at him. Behind him, Rozier was busy tending the fire. . . .

12 D'Arlandes threw some straw on the fire, but he couldn't stop looking down at all the places he knew, seeing them as a bird would.

13 Then something made a loud pop, then another. It sounded like ropes breaking. D'Arlandes saw a place where the balloon's fabric was burning.

14 "We must descend!" he cried.

descend = come down

15 But now they were over Paris itself. With all the buildings and chimneys, landing in the city would be dangerous.

16 To fight the fires, the men had only a bucket of water and one sponge apiece, but it was enough. As they rushed to put the sparks out, the balloon sank to rooftop level. Quickly, they stoked the main fire and rose out of danger. They landed safely in the country 25 minutes later, 5 miles (8 km) from their starting point. So ended the first human flight.

stoked = made stronger

| Balloon Firsts | |
|---|---|
| **June 5, 1783** | The Montgolfier brothers launch the first hot-air balloon |
| **August 27, 1783** | Professor Jacques Charles launches the first hydrogen balloon |
| **November 21, 1783** | Rozier and d'Arlandes are the first humans on a hot-air balloon |
| **March 2, 1784** | First time humans take flight in hydrogen balloon |
| **1793** | First balloon flight in the United States |

**20** What does "out of the question" mean as used in paragraph 1?

**A** a confusing action

**B** an important goal

**C** extremely interesting

**D** completely impossible

**21** Which sentence from the article **best** expresses a claim the author makes?

**A** "A lot of good science starts with simply paying attention and thinking about what you've seen." (paragraph 2)

**B** "If you've ever watched bits of ash rising with the smoke from a fire, you've seen it too." (paragraph 3)

**C** "And the king of France wouldn't allow it until one more experiment was made." (paragraph 6)

**D** "D'Arlandes leaned out, staring down at the crowd as they stared up at him." (paragraph 11)

**22** Read this sentence from paragraph 9.

> **He ran a science museum and invented an early type of gas mask to protect workers in sewers.**

What does the word "ran" mean as it is used in the sentence?

**A** moved at a fast speed

**B** was a candidate for a position

**C** was in charge of something

**D** passed quickly in a direction

**23** Which detail would be **most** important to include in a summary of the article?

**A** Étienne was a responsible and successful student when he was younger.

**B** Joseph experienced failure both in school and at business.

**C** Joseph and Étienne discovered that bags filled with hot air will rise up.

**D** Joseph and Étienne chose to avoid riding in their own balloon.

**24** Based on the article, how does making a deal with D'Arlandes help Rozier?

**A** D'Arlandes convinces the king to let them fly in a balloon.

**B** D'Arlandes gathers a large crowd to watch the balloon flight.

**C** D'Arlandes is skilled at using straw to keep a fire going.

**D** D'Arlandes is familiar with the streets and buildings in the city.

25 **This question is worth 2 credits.**

What is a central idea of the section "Hot Air Power"? Include your claim and use **two** details from the article to support your response.

**STOP**

**Name:** _____

# *New York State Testing Program*

# English Language Arts Test Session 2

# Grade 4

## Spring 2026

# RELEASED QUESTIONS

# Session 2

**TIPS FOR TAKING THE TEST**

Here are some ideas to help you do your best:

- Read the whole passage before you answer the questions. Most questions will only make sense after you read the whole passage.
- You might need to read the passage more than once to answer a question.
- Read each question carefully. Take your time.
- A question may include a quote from a passage. You might need to review both the quote and the whole passage to answer the question.

When you write your answers

- make sure to answer the whole question;
- use examples or details from the text;
- write in complete sentences; and
- use correct spelling, grammar, capitalization, and punctuation.

For the last question in this test book, you may plan your writing on the Planning Page provided. However, do NOT write your final answer on the Planning Page. Write your final answer on the lined pages.

*Directions*
**Read this article. Then answer questions 26 through 31.**

# Excerpt from "Building Green"

*by Cynthia Graber*

1 Students at the Calhoun School in New York City have much more than a roof over their heads. They have a rooftop garden, with lush grass, colorful flowers and fragrant herbs. Roofs covered in plants, or "green roofs," are sprouting up all over, from schools to city skyscrapers. And roofs aren't the only things going green.

2 Architects are finding all sorts of new ways to build buildings that are easier on the environment. These schools, homes, and offices are called "green buildings." . . .

**Stay Cool (and Warm)**

3 It takes a lot of energy to light rooms and run appliances. It also takes energy to heat buildings in the winter and air condition them in the summer. Too often, that energy comes from burning fossil fuels. So green buildings are designed to do all these things with much less energy.

> fossil fuels = fuel such as coal or oil that is formed from dead plants and animals

4 An energy-smart building starts with thick walls. A layer of insulation traps air to stop heat from passing through. That keeps heat inside in the winter, and keeps heat outside in the summer. This saves energy for heating and cooling. Some green buildings don't need any radiators or air conditioning at all!

5 Heat pumps are another power-saving way to stay comfy. A ground heat pump moves heat through a grid of pipes that run through the ground next to the building. A few feet under the ground, the temperature stays around 50° F (10° C) all year round. Water flowing around the pipes helps heat the building in winter and cool it in summer.

***GO ON***

**Sun Power**

6 In schools and libraries, lots of windows means plenty of natural light —and less need for electric light bulbs. Smart switches can turn the lights on when it gets dark. They can also tell when no one's in the room and turn the lights off.

7 The sun can supply natural heat as well as light. The Oberlin Center for Environmental Studies in Ohio was built with large south-facing windows. In winter, the sun shines in and heats the space. The floors are made of dark rock called slate. The sun warms the slate slowly during the day. At night, the slate releases the stored heat back into the air. In summer, shades over the windows keep the building cool.

8 Solar panels can help in two ways. Up on the roof or angled over windows, they provide cooling shade. At the same time, they convert sunlight into electricity. That electricity is stored in batteries and then used for lights, computers, and just about anything that can be turned on. . . .

convert = change

**Save the Trees . . .**

9 Another way to build green is to use recycled materials. That saves the cost and pollution of manufacturing something new. In the Chicago Center for Green Technology, the ceiling tiles are made of pressed newspaper. The bathroom floors are tiled with recycled glass, and the stall walls are recycled plastic. Even the building is recycled. Instead of putting up a new building, the builders gave a run-down old factory a green makeover.

10 Builders have found many creative ways to re-use old materials. Kitchen counters can be made from old ceramics, glass, and plastic. Some students in Guatemala and El Salvador are even building themselves new schools using plastic bottles packed with trash.

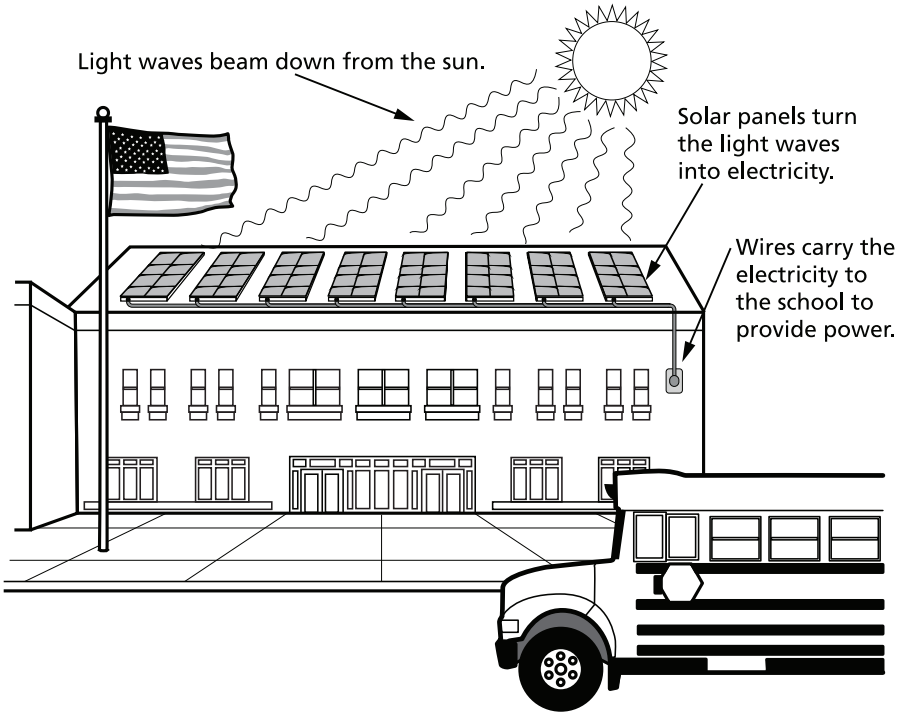
**A Better Home for All**

11 Green roofs are not just a fun place to hang out. They also save energy, water, and materials. An ordinary dark-colored roof absorbs lots of heat from the sun. In the summer, the temperature on the roof might soar to 170° F (77° C). That heats up the building underneath, so the air conditioner gets cranked up.

12 A green roof doesn't get as hot, so it keeps the building cooler. In the winter, the plants and soil act like a blanket to keep the building warm. When it rains, the soil and plants soak up rainwater, which means less water runs off into drains. Plants on the roof help clean the air and provide food for insects and birds, too.

13 As more people become concerned about climate change, more buildings are going green. Green buildings produce less of the gases that warm the planet. City planners like green buildings because they save money. And they are healthier for the people who work and live inside. But you don't need to build a whole new building. Simple changes like shading windows and planting trees can make any home greener—and a better Earth home for us all.

**How Solar Panels Power a School**



**26** Read this sentence from paragraph 1.

> **Roofs covered in plants, or "green roofs," are sprouting up all over, from schools to city skyscrapers.**

What does the word "sprouting" suggest?

**A** Rooftop gardens are good for all types of buildings.

**B** More green rooftops are being built than ever before.

**C** Buildings with green roofs can be easily seen.

**D** Plants grow better when they are on a roof.

**27** Many people believe you can turn trash into treasure. Which detail from the article **best** supports this idea?

**A** "Architects are finding all sorts of new ways to build buildings that are easier on the environment." (paragraph 2)

**B** "Builders have found many creative ways to re-use old materials." (paragraph 10)

**C** "When it rains, the soil and plants soak up rainwater, which means less water runs off into drains." (paragraph 12)

**D** "City planners like green buildings because they save money." (paragraph 13)

**28** How is paragraph 4 organized?

**A** by describing in order the steps for making a wall

**B** by stating an idea about thick walls and giving examples

**C** by sharing a reason for thick walls and the effects they have

**D** by comparing and contrasting different kinds of walls

**29** Based on the section "Sun Power," how do big windows make a building better for the environment?

**A** Windows can be covered by shades.

**B** Windows can be made from recycled glass.

**C** Windows are placed where solar panels could be.

**D** Windows allow in light and heat.

**30** How does the section "A Better Home for All" support a central idea of the article?

**A** by describing how green roofs on buildings save energy

**B** by explaining how soil helps plants in different weather conditions

**C** by stating that roofs that are dark become very hot from the sun

**D** by sharing that green buildings help city planners save money

**31** The diagram supports the information in the article by showing that

**A** wind power causes flags to move

**B** buildings can be built to help the environment

**C** a school bus can be powered by the sun

**D** solar panels change sunlight into electricity

*Directions*
**Read this article. Then answer questions 32 and 33.**

# Excerpt from *Orcas*

*by Anna Claybourne*

1 Orcas can do some amazing things. They leap high out of the water, detect food using echoes, and play with toys. They work as part of a team, learn to do tricks, and seem to be able to "talk" to each other. Like some other whales and dolphins, they are thought to be very intelligent.

2 Orcas will leap out of the sea and splash back down. This is called breaching. . . .

3 Although orcas only breathe air, they spend their whole lives in the sea. They are diurnal, which means they are active during the day. They spend most of their time traveling, hunting, resting, or just playing. . . .

**Half Asleep**

4 Like other whales and dolphins, orcas can't fall asleep completely, or they would not be able to come to the surface to breathe. Instead, one half of an orca's brain falls asleep, while the other half stays awake. Orcas can take naps at any time, but they usually spend a lot of the night snoozing. . . .

**Orca Groups**

5 Many orcas live in small family groups called matrilines. Each one is led by an orca mother. Even as adults, orcas can stay with their mother for as long as she is alive. Some young orcas go off and join other matrilines. . . .

6 A pod is a larger group of orcas, made up of several related matrilines. Pods of around 50 orcas often travel and feed together. Even bigger groups, called clans, are made up of all the related orcas in the area. . . .

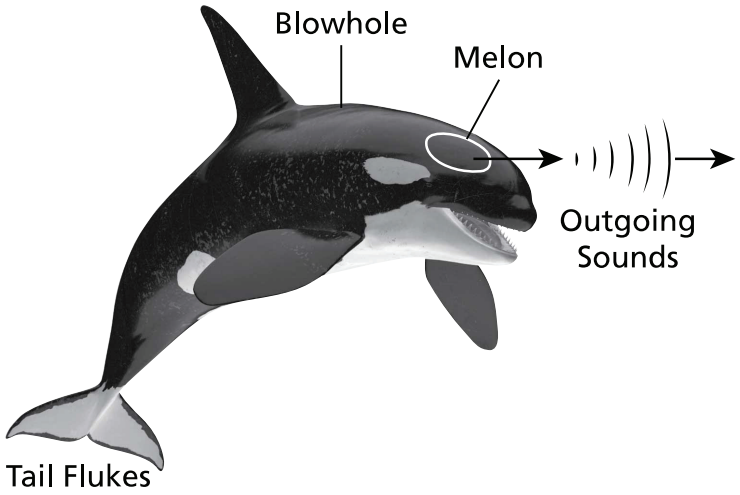
7 Orca calves constantly touch and nuzzle up to their mothers.

**Orca Talk**

8 Orcas are very good at communicating with each other. They make sounds by taking air in through their blowhole. However, the sound does not come out of the blowhole. Instead, the orca sends it through its melon. This fatty organ in its forehead seems to let it direct sound wherever it wants to. . . .

**Growing Up**

9 Like human children, orcas grow up slowly. They take around 10 years to reach adulthood and can live for more than 50 years. As orca calves grow up, they learn a lot from their mothers and from the others in their matriline and pod.



**32** **This question is worth 2 credits.**

According to *Orcas*, why do orcas sleep in an unusual way? Include your claim and use **two** details from the article to support your response.

33 **This question is worth 2 credits.**

In *Orcas*, how does the graphic help explain the information in paragraph 8? Include your claim and use **two** details from the article to support your response.

*Directions*

**Read this story. Then answer questions 34 and 35.**

*Granny is the leader of a family of orcas.*

# Excerpt from *Granny's Clan: A Tale of Wild Orcas*

*by Dr. Sally Hodson*

1 For a hundred summers and a hundred winters, the sea shared her secrets with Granny. Granny knows where salmon swim when tides change, or when winds shift, or waters warm, or winter storms blow. With Granny in the lead, the family spreads out to hunt.

2 They swim through ribbons of dancing brown kelp, among seals searching for rockfish, near an octopus clutching a crab, above sea stars stretched over rocks, close to pelicans diving for fish snacks, under jellyfish drifting with tides.

3 They swim past herons stalking on stick legs, beside sea otters dining on urchins, over hermit crabs hiding in seashells, around sea birds surfing on breakers, beneath bald eagles soaring with winds, by a humpback whale playing in waves.

4 Each of the family sends out beams of sonar clicks. CLICK-CLICK-CLICK!

sonar clicks = sounds that orcas make

5 They listen as their sounds bounce off rocks, fish, and sea life. ECHO-ECHO-ECHO!

6 The echoes return as "pictures" made of sounds. In darkness, they "see" how big, far, fast, and what shape. Shark to the right! Squid to the left! Salmon ahead! With a burst of speed, they overtake the salmon. Calls to each other flow back and forth. Tail flukes slap the sea with thunder. Swirls of silver salmon flee. Empty orca bellies fill. . . .

7 The family seeks rest in a quiet cove. They gather close together and drift with the waves. Soft calls flow from one to another. They doze. They dream. They remember to breathe. . . .

8 When the family awakens, Granny sings the clan song of coming together.

9 Through miles of deep water canyons, Granny's powerful voice travels to find the other clan families.

10 From near and far, each family answers the Eldest Clan Grandmother with their own family call. *We are coming.*

11 All the clan families, mothers and grandmothers, daughters and sons, brothers and sisters, uncles and aunties, grandsons and granddaughters come together again. A great SUPERPOD gathers! They greet old friends. They welcome new babies. They remember lost ones. They celebrate togetherness.

**34** **This question is worth 2 credits.**

In *Granny's Clan*, how does the information in paragraph 11 add to the information in paragraph 8? Include your claim and use **two** details from the story to support your response.

*Planning Page*

**You may PLAN your writing for question 35 here if you wish, but do NOT write your final answer on this page. Writing on this Planning Page will NOT count toward your final score. Write your final answer on Pages 17 and 18.**



35 **This question is worth 4 credits.**

What is a central idea of the article *Orcas*? What is a central idea of the story *Granny's Clan*? How are the central ideas of the article and the story similar? Use details from **both** the article and the story to support your response.

In your response, be sure to

- identify a central idea of the article
- identify a central idea of the story
- explain how the central ideas of the article and the story are similar
- use details from **both** the article and the story to support your response